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Bánh Mì Nướng Tôm (Vietnamese Shrimp Toast)

Yield: ~36–40 pieces (about 2 baguettes' worth) · Active 20 min · Total 35 min

Baked baguette slices topped with a creamy shrimp-and-crab paste. A party-platter staple — Vietnamese in seasoning, Cantonese in ancestry, with a Korean chili edge in this version.

Ingredients

Seafood base

Ingredient	Amount
Raw shrimp, peeled & deveined	1 lb / 450 g
Imitation crab	8 oz / 225 g

Binder

Ingredient	Amount
Mayonnaise (Kewpie preferred)	$\frac{1}{3}$ cup / 80 g
Low-moisture mozzarella, shredded	1 cup / 113 g, plus $\frac{1}{4}$ cup extra for topping
Unsalted butter, melted	1 tbsp (<i>optional</i>)

Seasoning

Ingredient	Amount
Fish sauce	1 tbsp
Kosher salt	½ tsp
Granulated sugar	½ tsp
White pepper	½ tsp
Toasted sesame oil	2 tsp
Sriracha	1–2 tbsp
Gochugaru (Korean red pepper flakes)	1–2 tsp

Aromatics

Ingredient	Amount
Green onion, finely chopped	4–5 stalks (~½ cup), reserve some green tops for garnish
Garlic, minced	4 cloves (~1 tbsp)
Celery, finely diced	¼ cup (<i>optional</i>)

Bread

Ingredient	Amount
Baguettes	2 loaves

Procedure

1. Pat the shrimp thoroughly dry. Chop by hand to a rough mince — pea-sized pieces, not a purée. If using a food processor, pulse in short bursts and stop while the texture is still uneven; over-processing gives a rubbery, pâté-like result.
2. Shred or roughly chop the imitation crab into similar-sized pieces.

3. Combine the shrimp, crab, mayonnaise, 1 cup mozzarella, butter, fish sauce, salt, sugar, white pepper, sesame oil, sriracha, gochugaru, green onion, garlic, and celery – reserving the ¼ cup extra cheese and some green onion tops for garnish. Mix thoroughly until it forms a cohesive, scoopable paste that holds a mound on a spoon. If it slumps, add cheese a tablespoon at a time; if it's stiff and crumbly, add mayo a tablespoon at a time.
4. Pan-fry a teaspoon of the mixture for 60 seconds and taste it. Adjust salt/fish sauce before committing the rest of the batch.
5. Rest the paste 20 minutes (or overnight) – the salt firms up the shrimp proteins and the mixture binds noticeably better.
6. Slice baguettes ½–¾ inch thick, straight down for bite-sized pieces or on a diagonal for larger ones.
7. Toast the bare slices at 350 °F / 175 °C for 4–5 minutes until dry to the touch. This is the single biggest defence against a soggy base, and essential if assembling ahead.
8. Spread about 2 tbsp of paste per slice, edge to edge, roughly ¼ inch thick. Press down gently so it adheres. Sprinkle the reserved cheese over the tops.
9. Bake at 350 °F / 175 °C for 12–14 minutes, until the cheese is golden and bubbling and the shrimp is opaque and set.
10. Move to the top rack and broil 2–3 minutes for a golden, blistered surface – watch it continuously at this stage.
11. Garnish with reserved green onion. Serve immediately; the crust softens within about 20 minutes.

Notes

- **Shrimp:** 31/40 count is fine; pat very dry before chopping.
- **Imitation crab** is already salted – factor that in before adding extra salt.
- **Mayonnaise:** up to ½ cup for a looser, creamier spread.
- **Cheese choice.** Mozzarella alone is stretchy but browns poorly and sheds water. A Mexican blend, mild cheddar, or colby-jack browns better. Half mozzarella / half cheddar is a good compromise.
- **Sesame oil** is potent – resist going higher than 2 tsp.
- **Salt:** reduce the ½ tsp kosher salt if the crab is very salty.
- **Fresh crab:** substitute 1:1 for imitation crab, but drop the sugar and add salt at the end – real crab is far less sweet and less salty.
- **Make-ahead:** paste keeps 1 day refrigerated; assembled toasts hold 8 h before baking.
- **Air fryer:** 375 °F / 190 °C for 10–12 minutes, no pre-toast needed.
- **Pan-fried version** (bánh mì chiên tôm): spread on untoasted slices and fry paste-side down in ½ inch of oil, 3–4 minutes, then flip briefly.
- **Freezing:** freeze assembled, unbaked toasts flat on a tray, then bag. Bake from frozen at 400 °F / 205 °C for 18–20 minutes.
- **Scaling ratios**, anchored to shrimp weight: imitation crab ≈ 50% of shrimp weight; cheese ≈ 25%; mayo ≈ 18% (adjust to consistency, not to the number); ~2 tbsp paste per slice; about 1 baguette per 1¼ lb of paste.